Chicken Tinga

Ingredients

Lard . . . . . 2 Tbsp.
White onion, diced . . . . . 1 medium
Garlic cloves, minced 4
Mexican spice blend . . . . . 2 Tbsp.
Chicken leg quarters . . . . . 4 lb.
Diced tomatoes . . . . . 1 (14.5 oz.) can
Chipotle chiles in adobo . . . 1 (8 oz.) can
Chicken broth . . . . . 1 cup
Bay leaf 1
Lime, juiced 1
Kosher salt . . . . . to taste
Fresh cilantro, chopped . . . . . 1/4 cup

Directions

Dice the **white onion** — Mince the **garlic** — Measure the **Mexican spice blend** — Open the **tomatoes** and the **chipotle chiles** — Measure the **chicken broth** — Juice the **lime** — Chop the **cilantro**

1. Set a 6-quart Instant Pot to Sauté (Normal). Add 2 Tbsp. **lard** and heat until it shimmers. Add the **white onion** and cook, stirring, for *5–7 minutes*, until the pieces are translucent and soft, the edges just take on color, and the pot looks glossy rather than watery. Continue cooking for *1–2 minutes* if the onion is still crisp or sitting in liquid.

2. Add the **garlic** and 2 Tbsp. **Mexican spice blend**. Stir constantly for *30–45 seconds*, until the mixture smells fragrant and the raw spice smell turns toasty.

3. Nestle in the **leg quarters**. Add the **tomatoes**, the **chipotle chiles** with their sauce, 1 cup **chicken broth**, and the **bay leaf**. Scrape the bottom so the fond dissolves into the liquid. The liquid should cover the pot floor and come partway up the **chicken**. Cancel Sauté.

4. Seal the lid and set the valve to Sealing. Cook on high pressure for *15 minutes*. Let the pressure fall on its own for *10 minutes*, then turn the valve to Venting and release any pressure that remains. The **chicken** is done when the thickest part near the bone reads at least *165°F*.

5. Transfer the **chicken** to a cutting board with tongs.

6. Discard the **bay leaf**. Blend the sauce in the pot with an immersion blender until it is smooth and brick-red, with no pieces of chile, tomato, or onion left, about *30–60 seconds*. Keep the blender head under the surface so the hot sauce stays in the pot. Blend for another *15–20 seconds* if any pieces remain.

7. Set the pot to Sauté (Normal) and simmer the sauce uncovered, stirring often, for *8–15 minutes*, until it coats the back of a spoon. The surface looks glossy, and the sauce still stirs easily. Stir so the bottom does not catch. While it simmers, pull the skin, bones, and any gristle off the **chicken** and shred the meat with two forks into coarse strands.

8. Ladle just enough sauce onto the shredded chicken to thoroughly coat it, mixing until every strand is glossy and saucy but not swimming. Reserve and refrigerate or freeze any extra sauce for a future batch or use as a smoky, spicy condiment.

9. Cancel Sauté. Stir in the **lime juice**. Taste. The adobo has already salted the sauce. Add **kosher salt** only if the sauce tastes flat. Scatter the **cilantro** over the top. The tinga is at its best as soon as the **cilantro** goes on. It holds warm in the pot for about *30 minutes*. Stir in a spoonful of water if it tightens while it waits.

Equipment Required

- 6-quart or larger Instant Pot
- Immersion blender
- Tongs
- Two forks
- Cutting board
- Chef's knife
- Wooden spoon or spatula
- Measuring cups and spoons
- Can opener
- Instant-read thermometer

Hints and Notes

Yield

- One 6-quart Instant Pot batch from 3½–4 lb. bone-in **leg quarters**.

Mise en Place

- Pull the skin off the **leg quarters** and trim loose fat
- Dice the **white onion** and mince the **garlic**
- Measure 2 Tbsp. **Mexican spice blend** and 1 cup **chicken broth**
- Open the **tomatoes** and the can of **chipotle chiles**
- Juice the **lime** and chop the **cilantro** so both are ready at the end
- Set the immersion blender, tongs, and cutting board beside the pot before you seal the lid

Ingredient Tips

- **Leg quarters**: bone-in, skin off. Go by weight. About four quarters land in the 3½–4 lb. range. The bones and the long cook give the sauce body.
- **Chipotle chiles**: use the entire 8 oz. can, peppers and sauce. Many grocery cans are labeled 7 oz. Use that whole can the same way. A full can is hot, smoky, and salty.
- **Mexican spice blend**: use the blend in this book. It brings cumin, oregano, and a little clove and cinnamon under the chipotle.
- **Lard**: traditional, and it softens the chile heat. Vegetable oil or corn oil works in its place.
- **Tomatoes**: fire-roasted diced tomatoes add char. Plain diced tomatoes work, with less roast flavor.
- **Chicken broth**: use low-sodium broth. The adobo already seasons the pot. The cup of broth lets the pot reach pressure. The later simmer is what makes the sauce thick.
- **White onion**: the usual onion for tinga. A yellow onion is fine.

Preparation Tips

- **Pot fill**: stack the **leg quarters** so the food stays under the two-thirds line. An 8-quart pot gives more room for 4 lb. of bone-in chicken.
- **Onion**: let the onion liquid cook off before the **garlic** and spices go in. Spices bloom in fat. They taste raw if they hit a wet pot.
- **Bay leaf**: take it out before blending. A blended leaf leaves bitter flecks in the sauce.
- **Blender**: keep the head under the surface and pulse. A head above the sauce throws hot liquid.

- **Reduction**: the **chicken** releases a lot of juice under pressure, and the can adds more liquid. Judge the sauce by the spoon test, not by the clock.
- **Salt**: taste after the **lime**. Add **kosher salt** only if the sauce tastes flat. Reducing the sauce makes the adobo salt stronger.
- **Shred**: coarse strands hold up in a taco. Paste-fine shreds turn soft in the sauce.
- **Fat**: leave the rendered fat in the sauce. It carries the chipotle and rounds the heat.

Make Ahead & Storage

- The tinga is better the next day. Cool it, then refrigerate up to *4 days*.
- Freeze up to *3 months*. Thaw overnight in the refrigerator.
- Reheat on the stovetop over low heat. Add a splash of **broth** if the sauce has tightened.
- Add the **cilantro** after reheating so it stays green.
- The best moment is right after the **lime** and **cilantro** go on. Warm tinga holds in the pot for about *30 minutes*.

Serving Suggestions

- Spoon into warm corn tortillas, onto tostadas, or into tortas.
- Top with diced **white onion**, avocado, queso fresco, and a squeeze of **lime**.
- Serve with Mexican rice and beans.
- A Mexican lager or a hibiscus agua fresca stands up to the chile.